Wireless Woes

Check your newspaper, radio, or television newscast this week and you'll likely see information about the latest wireless technology to hit the streets. Actually it's about the ONLY technology news you'll hear about today as everyone out there scrambles to find the next big thing to latch onto before the economy craps out on us. I kind of like wireless technology for things like phone calls and short e-mail messages from info services, but there's a problem brewing on the horizon.

Turn back the clock a couple of years. The internet was on the verge of taking off, and anyone with a few thousand bucks to throw around was throwing it at anyone who could string together two lines of HTML code and get them online. It didn't matter if the business plan reeked like forty-day old milk (and not the Parmalot stuff either). Hell, it didn't matter if the wasn't any business plan at all, people would still shove millions into your shorts if you had dot com after your business name.

Then look what happened, about two years later the economy is going south faster than a seabird in September, and all those people who couldn't wait to give someone else their hard-earned cash are coming to the frightening realization that they ain't getting it back. Investing in technology and businesses that didn't stand a chance turned out to be a very bad idea – who knew?

Now let's look at the wireless technology scene. Listening to the pundits of today's reports you'll soon be able to do anything over a wireless connection. Buy stocks, bonds, baby supplies and anything else. Get e-mail, streaming video, music, and all sorts of entertainment. Wow, a total digital utopia in a tiny little mobile phone package.

And that is where this whole mess starts to unravel (or rather it will in a few months). Let's begin with the visual stuff. Look at your mobile phones (or someone's, I promise I won't tell). See that tiny little screen? I don't know about you but I certainly can't imagine buying much of anything through that – let's not even talk about video playback.

No, let's talk about video playback. I can't even get that to work without skips, jumps and static on my PC with a DSL connection – do you really think it's going to work on a mobile connection that can't keep my phone conversations going reliably most of the time?

Alright, so there are some mobile companies offering bigger screens and better bandwidth – at prices that rival what most of us pay for our utility bills every month. J.Q. Public is going to get stuck with that tiny screen and a pipe the size of a pin for the foreseeable future – meaning most of these wonderful wireless apps just aren't going to fly (oh wait, bad analogy, you can't use most of these things on airplanes anyway).

So what are we to do? First off, look at all the news reports with a skeptical eye – don't jump into a brand new market just because it looks cool. Wait this one out and see if wireless companies look toward more viable applications. I don't know about you but I'm planning to find good technology on traditional hardware, wait out the crashing stock markets, and use my mobile phone as. . . well. . . a phone.

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